

nationhood could not be enforced, leaving the children of immigrants stranded, feeling part of both and neither culture. A recent BBC survey showed that nearly 40 per cent of the people of Asian descent regard themselves as 'slightly or not at all' British. This lack of loyalty led directly to the obscenity of the 7/7 London bombings, when men who were born and bred in England blew up themselves and their fellow citizens. Their only allegiance was to a synthetic external identity. Leaving aside the specifics of Kashmir, India has thrown up almost no international

asylum. Would you want to live in Nepal, where Maoists call the shots and a nation awaits the end of monarchy? And look at the experiment in Pakistan, where President Musharraf is buying time trying to kill the jihadis before they kill him.

The economic boost of the last 10 years has engineered a propulsion in Indian society that has changed the way people think about themselves. Although authors who make a living by writing for foreign publishers tend to claim that the vulgarity of the new rich and the injustices of the Indian state negate this transformation, it is clear that the



SHAILESH RAVAL

HOMESPUN: Khadi became a pan-Indian symbol

Islamist terrorists, unlike most other countries with large Muslim populations. The exceptions are the failed Glasgow car bomber Kafeel Ahmed, and the Al-Qaeda linkman Dhiren Barot (a convert from a Hindu family), both of whom were radicalised in Britain. Despite suspicious murmurings from the saffron right, Indian Muslims show a remarkable loyalty to their country.

Being Indian is a powerful identity, internationally recognised in a way that being, say, Burkinabe, is not. The days when an ambitious person had to try to escape overseas are long gone; instead, successful businessmen return in the hope of making money and rediscovering a land they had lost. Indians who live abroad like to exist on their own terms in a state of suspended animation, going to each other's weddings and family parties, imagining they are still at home. Much of this national glee comes from an accurate conviction that neighbouring countries are in a worse state, and make India look good by comparison. Who needs to worry about foeticide in Punjab or the hundreds of millions of people who still live in extreme poverty when you know what is happening in Afghanistan? Would you like to be Bangladeshi, with half your country set to disappear as sea levels rise from global warming over the coming decades? Who wants to be Tibetan, under Chinese Communist rule? Does Sri Lanka look like a model nation? Or try Burma, where the lunatics have taken over the

Schoolchildren are taught that the country comes before everything else. It is a kind of brainwashing, but it has been remarkably effective, and underpins India's unity.

unshackling extends way beyond the flamboyant few who can be seen on page three. Indians have a chance to shape their own destiny in a way that has never been possible before. You can move to your own house using a home loan and live outside the joint family. You can buy a car that is not an Ambassador or a Fiat. It is possible to travel abroad and see how people in other countries live. You can watch your politicians accept bribes or dance with prostitutes on TV while surfing your way to *Desperate Housewives*. In an inversion of the early roles of his father—the angry young rebel who resisted being crushed—Abhishek Bachchan can be seen in the recent movie *Guru* extolling the joys of capitalism. In a remarkable speech to a government enquiry, which would have been inconceivable on the silver screen even a decade ago, he talks of walking in the steps of Bapu and declares the need for a second freedom. The first freedom was from foreign rule; the second freedom is the right to run a profitable business without government restriction, and to make money.

What unites India now? The old manufactured sense of history, the enduring strength of family ties, *schadenfreude* about the neighbours, an extreme form of democracy, some residual faith in the generation of ideal boys, a continuing sense of loyalty from most citizens towards the national project that would be rare in other countries. Above all, India today is united by a sense of possibility.



Patrick French is the author of *Liberty or Death: India's Journey to Independence and Division*. His biography of V.S. Naipaul will be published in Spring 2008.